



GARY CORONADO For The Times

AN OFFICER questions a woman in Celaya, Mexico. Nine out of 10 Mexicans distrust the police.

Reform fades as violence rises

Mexican city once vowed to revamp its police. That has been abandoned as the country deploys the military to fight cartels.

By Kate Linthicum

CELAYA, Mexico — On a sunny spring day last year, a young attorney named Gisela Gaytán kicked off her campaign for mayor in this gritty Mexican city.

Under her blouse she wore a ballistic vest.

Celaya had become the epicenter of a bloody cartel war, with one of the highest homicide rates in the world, and a local police force that appeared powerless to stop it.

“We must recover the security that we so long for,” Gaytán, 38, wrote on social media before setting out that day.

As she shook hands at an event

on the outskirts of town, a man approached, raised a gun and shot her in the head.

After her funeral, where a priest lamented “a death caused by murderers who believe they control society,” local Morena party leaders picked a new candidate: Juan Miguel Ramírez Sánchez, a bespectacled former university rector who had worked on Gaytán’s campaign.

Ramírez believed that one of Celaya’s most urgent problems was its police, who instead of fighting organized crime appeared to be involved in it.

His son-in-law had been killed in a murder that was still unsolved, and officers had demanded bribes and obstructed the investigation. Police misconduct was well documented: Local cops were prosecuted for abusing detainees and participating in kidnappings and even homicides.

Ramírez won the election. And in his first act as mayor, he fired 340 of the roughly 600 officers on the force. Then — as officials across Mexico have been doing for nearly two decades now — he called in federal troops.

[See Mexico, A4]

All dark horses in governor’s race?

With Kamala Harris out, some analysts say the contest will be a free-for-all for a while.

By KEVIN RECTOR, SEEMA MEHTA AND LAURA J. NELSON

For months, candidates in the race to become California’s next governor had waited for a pivotal question to be settled: Will former Vice President Kamala Harris run or not?

With Harris’ announcement last week that she is out, a new question arose: Who’s the front-runner now?

Because of Harris’ star power, the answer is far from simple. For months, other

candidates saw their campaign planning and fundraising undercut by the possibility she would run, meaning the race got a big reset seconds after Harris made her announcement Wednesday.

Some political observers give the nod to former U.S. Rep. Katie Porter, who appears to have a small leg up over her opponents.

Porter was the only Democrat to receive double-digit support in multiple polls when Harris was not included in the field.

A prodigious fundraiser while she was in Congress representing an Orange County district, Porter reported a strong infusion of cash in the months after launching her campaign in March, and said she raised

[See Campaign, A7]

Murdoch becomes Trump’s unlikely rival

Legal feud with Wall Street Journal marks a breach in a mutually beneficial alliance.

By MEG JAMES

President Trump once called Rupert Murdoch “my very good friend.”

But the 94-year-old media baron, whose fortunes have risen in tandem with Trump’s political ascent, has turned into an unlikely foe.

Trump has bristled over a Wall Street Journal report that he allegedly sent a suggestive letter to sex offender Jeffrey Epstein for his 50th birthday in 2003. Trump denied sending the message,

calling it a “fake,” and last month he filed a \$10-billion defamation suit against Journal publisher Dow Jones & Co., Murdoch and others.

The billionaire — who sits at the top of the world’s most prominent conservative media empire — has become the focus of the president’s fury.

“I hope Rupert and his ‘friends’ are looking forward to the many hours of depositions and testimonies they will have to provide in this case,” Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform, a nod to “Fox & Friends,” one of his favorite TV programs. The Journal, he wrote, is a “Disgusting and Filthy Rag,” and Murdoch’s “‘pile of garbage’ newspaper.”

Trump’s attorneys ap- [See Murdoch, A12]



AL SEIB For The Times

JINAH KIM had faced a \$500 daily fine for a doorway renovation in her condo.

‘A game changer’: State law limits HOA fines to \$100

California experts and lobbyists are surprised by new cap on levies for defying rules.

By JACK FLEMMING

Jinah Kim’s homeowners association said she couldn’t fix a doorway inside her condo. She did it anyway.

She figured it was fine. After all, the doorway was completely inside her home, separating an office and dining room. But when the complex’s manager peeked into her place through the open garage door one day in March and saw the renovation, she received a notice

the next day.

The privacy intrusion was shocking, but the cost of noncompliance was even worse: a single \$100 fine at first, then up to \$500 per day — \$3,500 per week — starting July 10 until she changed the doorway back.

But on July 1, when Gov. Gavin Newsom signed Assembly Bill 130 into law, her HOA nightmare vanished with the stroke of a pen, and her fee for defiance was capped at \$100.

“It’s a game changer,” Kim said. “For years, HOAs have been able to bend entire communities to their will on a whim. This stops that.”

Industry experts and HOA lobbyists were taken by surprise in June when

Newsom pushed AB 130 through the state Legislature and signed it into law — not because it passed, but because it included a last-minute update redefining HOA law in California. The overall goal of the bill is to expedite housing by easing California Environmental Quality Act regulations for many projects, but it also amends the Davis-Stirling Act, the framework that governs homeowners associations.

The biggest change? HOA fines are now capped at \$100 per violation unless there are health or safety impacts. Want to paint your house neon green? \$100. Erect a giant Halloween skeleton on your front lawn

[See HOA, A9]

Doncic signs new deal with Lakers

Star commits with a three-year contract extension and says the team is ready to compete for title. **SPORTS, D1**

Conjunto pioneer Jiménez dies

Tejano music legend, accordion master and six-time Grammy winner “Flaco” Jiménez was 86. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Making films amid an AI push

New tools are changing how movies are created. What that means for filmmakers and crews. **ENTERTAINMENT, E6**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 84/64. **B10**



9th Circuit keeps freeze on patrols by ICE in SoCal

Federal appeals court deals blow to Trump administration’s mass deportation project.

By SONJA SHARP AND JULIA WICK

The 9th U.S. Circuit Court of Appeals dealt a stinging blow to the Trump administration’s mass deportation project Friday night in a fiery opinion upholding a lower court’s block on “roving patrols” across much of Southern California.

“If, as Defendants suggest, they are not conducting stops that lack reasonable suspicion, they can hardly claim to be irreparably harmed by an injunction aimed at preventing a subset of stops not supported by reasonable suspicion,” the panel wrote.

The ruling leaves in place a temporary restraining order barring masked and heavily armed agents from snatching people off the streets of Southern California without first establishing reasonable suspicion that they are in the U.S. illegally.

Under the 4th Amendment, reasonable suspicion cannot be based solely on race, ethnicity, language, location or employment, either alone or in combination, U.S. District Judge Maame Ewusi-Mensah Frimpong of Los Angeles wrote in her original order.

9th Circuit Judges Marsha S. Berzon, Jennifer Sung and Ronald M. Gould

agreed.

“There is no predicate action that the individual plaintiffs would need to take, other than simply going about their lives, to potentially be subject to the challenged stops,” the opinion said.

Fourth Amendment injunctions are hard to win, experts say. Plaintiffs must show not only that they were hurt, but that they are likely to be hurt again in the same way in the future.

One way to meet that test [See ICE, A7]

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

Lien filings prone to political misuse

False debt claims, damaging to credit and careers, aim to punish public officials.

By MELODY GUTIERREZ

SACRAMENTO — Texas real estate agent Tara Jarrett opened the online class with a prayer, bowing her head and closing her eyes.

“Dear Heavenly Father,” she began. “I ask that you would just speak to me and through me as I deliver this detailed message tonight.”

What followed was a lesson on revenge.

Jarrett walked the attendees, logged in from California and other states, through the process of filing liens to punish public officials, such as politicians and judges, who they alleged aren’t upholding their oaths of office. Those liens are recorded in state Uniform Commercial Code databases, public filings intended to alert creditors about business debts and financial obligations.

“This is how we level the playing field,” Jarrett, 52, told her class in a video uploaded last year. “We don’t sue government officials. We file liens that crush their credit until they cooperate.”

Across the country, antagonists and antigovernment “sovereign citizens” are flooding states and counties with liens like the ones Jarrett and others show how to file. In the claims, they often allege government officials owe them money or property, a tactic the U.S. Justice Department and nonpartisan Congressional Research Service have identified as a form of “paper terrorism.” Other filings aren’t about retribution. Instead, they’re financial maneuvers aimed at businesses, claiming to be owed cash, cars and homes.

Consumer credit expert John Ulzheimer said these liens can complicate a person’s ability to obtain a mortgage or a business’ chances of securing lines of

[See Liens, A10]